

Antonino Costa

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EDUCATION

The Hong Kong University of Science and Technology <i>Ph.D. in Accounting</i>	Hong Kong, China September 2022 - Present
The Hong Kong University of Science and Technology <i>M.Sc. in Accounting (Accounting Analytics Concentration)</i>	Hong Kong, China September 2021 - May 2022
Bocconi University <i>B.Sc. in Business Administration and Management</i>	Milan, Italy September 2018 - July 2021

RESEARCH

RESEARCH INTERESTS

Corporate Governance, Political Economy, Social Networks

WORKING PAPERS

The Impact of Politicians' Personal Financial Disclosures on Connected Firms' Voluntary Disclosure (Solo Authored)

Job Market Paper

- Committee: Zhihong Chen (Chair), Qingkai Dong, and Arthur Morris

The Impact of Municipal-Auditor Appointments on Auditors' Private-Sector Audit Engagements (with Zhihong Chen and Qingkai Dong)

Conditionally Accepted at the Journal of Accounting Research

- Presented at the National University of Singapore, Singapore Management University, the Hong Kong University of Science and Technology, the 47th EAA Annual Congress, and the 2nd Mediterranean Accounting Conference.

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

THE HONG KONG UNIVERSITY OF SCIENCE AND TECHNOLOGY

Course Instructor

Principles of Accounting I (Teaching Evaluation: 4.50/5.00) Summer 2025

Teaching Assistant

Principles of Accounting II (Instructor: Steven Cheung) Spring 2025

Principles of Accounting I (Instructor: Steven Cheung) Fall 2024

PRESENTATIONS

European Accounting Association 47 th Annual Congress	2025
The Hong Kong University of Science and Technology	2025

CONFERENCES

CAPANA Annual Research Conference	2026
CAPANA Doctoral Consortium	2026
Hawaii Accounting Research Doctoral Institute	2026
Accounting and Economics Society Annual Conference	2025
Accounting and Economics Society Summer School	2025
HKUST Accounting Research Symposium	2022, 2023, 2024, 2025
HKUST Business School PhD Student Conference	2023, 2024, 2025

HONORS & SCHOLARSHIPS

Hong Kong Ph.D. Fellowship Scheme	2022-Present
Beta Gamma Sigma	2023
HKUST RedBird Ph.D. Award	2022
HKUST M.Sc. in Accounting Achievement Scholarship	2022
HKUST M.Sc. in Accounting Admission Scholarship	2021

SKILLS & PROFESSIONAL MEMBERSHIPS

Programming	Python, R, SQL, $\LaTeX$
Memberships	European Accounting Association; Accounting and Economics Society
Languages	English (fluent), Italian (native), Putonghua (intermediate), French (intermediate)
HKUST Sports	Standard Chartered Hong Kong Marathon (2025)
Team	Standard Chartered Hong Kong Marathon (Half Marathon) (2024)
	The University Sports Federation of Hong Kong Cross Country Race (2023)

REFERENCES

Zhihong Chen (Chair)

Associate Professor of Accounting

HKUST Business School

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Qingkai Dong

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Arthur Morris

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The Impact of Politicians' Personal Financial Disclosures on Connected Firms' Voluntary Disclosure

This paper examines how the public disclosure of an individual-firm connection affects the firm's voluntary financial disclosure. Italy's personal financial disclosure mandate requires politicians of municipalities with more than 15,000 residents to publish their managerial appointments, asset holdings, and tax filings. These disclosures make connected firms identifiable and attribute their financial statements to the politician. Exploiting the mandate's unexpected extension to incumbent politicians, I compare firms whose connections were exposed with firms connected to exempt politicians. Following the mandate, connected firms reduce voluntary financial disclosure. The reduction is confined to connections the mandate exposes for the first time, to municipalities where voters are attentive and attribute business income to public office, and to the tails of the firm performance distribution, where financial statements are most revealing. The pattern is consistent with politicians' privacy cost of disclosure and inconsistent with signaling legitimacy or concealing rent extraction. Treated politicians become more likely to be covered in articles on their income, and those connected to a firm face worse reelection outcomes. Overall, the evidence suggests that transparency mandates directed at individuals generate information spillovers that make connected firms more opaque.

The Impact of Municipal-Auditor Appointments on Auditors' Private-Sector Audit Engagements

This paper examines how municipal-auditor appointments affect auditors' private-sector audit engagements. Leveraging the lottery-based selection of municipal auditors in Italy, we compare first-time appointees with auditors who have never been appointed. We find that appointed auditors acquire more private clients and expand the geographic reach of their practices, although these clients are not necessarily located closer to the appointing municipalities. These effects are more pronounced for less experienced auditors and in more competitive audit markets. The increase in private clients appears to be primarily driven by greater visibility and networks with other municipal auditors, rather than connections with politicians. We also show that local municipal appointments motivate other auditors to become eligible for future drafts, as evidenced by an increase in new professional registrations. Overall, our findings highlight the role of professional experience gained through municipal-auditor service in shaping labor market outcomes within the auditing profession.